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Keeping public safe is main priority in Woolsey fire, officials tell evacuees at Town Hall

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Keeping everyone safe from the Woolsey fire is the priority above all else, fire officials and local leaders told hundreds of people – many among the 250,000 evacuees – who attended a Town Hall at Taft Charter High School in Woodland Hills on Sunday, Nov. 11.

Many attendees were upset that they haven't been given updates on the status of their homes. While some celebrities in the Malibu area have already learned the status of their homes, others pleaded with officials for an answer on when they could return to theirs.

But with two people who were found burned and dead in their car Friday in the Malibu area, officials made it clear that safety is being prioritized over letting people come back to their homes.

"(Fire officials) are taking an abundance of precautions to protect your lives," state Sen. Henry Stearns said, referencing the fatalities in Malibu and 20-plus in the Camp Fire in Northern California.

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While containment of the fire grew to 15 percent on Sunday night, Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel said that the entire city of Calabasas is now under mandatory evacuation. The fire has burned some 85,500 acres as of Sunday night, according to Cal Fire.

Los Angeles County Fire Chief Deputy of Emergency Operations David Richardson said the ever-changing winds are making the Woolsey Fire unpredictable.

"This is by far the quickest and fastest moving fire I have witnessed and been a part of," said Richardson, who has 30-plus years of firefighting experience.

The multiple fires have spread the firefighting resources thin, but out-of-state help is on the way, Richardson said.

Los Angeles County Sheriff's Department Chief of North Patrol John Benedict asked residents of areas still evacuated not to return to their homes yet.

"They are not yet rendered safe," he said, adding that many of the areas are still disastrous.

Benedict said the homicide bureau is still investigating the two Malibu fatalities during the fire, but an early assessment by the Sheriff Department's homicide bureau is that they believe the driver may have become disorientated while trying to evacuate and then was overcome by the fire.

Officials acknowledged evacuees' frustrations on not knowing the status of their homes, but emphasized that it is to keep them safe.

Town Hall attendees expressed concerns about the 3,000-plus Pepperdine University students who stayed on the campus despite the fire encroaching, with some saying they felt firefighting efforts were focused there instead of other parts of Malibu.

"We cannot sacrifice the rest of Malibu for Pepperdine," Stearns said.

But a few moments later, Pepperdine student Currie Dickerson told Stearns and other attendees that the school's community were still grappling with the death of a student who was killed at the Borderline mass shooting that killed 12 on Wednesday. Dickerson said she didn't necessarily defend with the school's decision to shelter in place, but that the students were still in shock and mourning.

"Students were very confused and hurt in the past few days," she said.

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